Blame, Credit, and Coverage: Media Attention and Presidential Particularism in U.S. Federal Disaster Relief

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The Question



Figure: Durango Herald (2013)

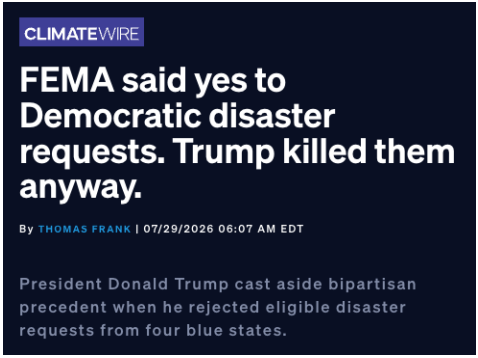


Figure: Politico (2026)

- Normatively, federal relief should be allocated on **objective need** alone ...
  - Evidence that **electoral incentives** shape domestic disaster response (e.g., Reeves, 2011; Schneider & Kunze, 2025)
  - Evidence that **news coverage** influences U.S. relief to foreign disasters (Eisensee & Strömberg 2007)

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- **Two Questions:**
  1. Does news coverage work the same way in domestic disasters?
  2. Does news coverage interact with electoral incentives?

How does news salience affect FEMA disaster aid disbursement, and how does that effect interact with political incentives?

Consumers of domestic news are both voters **and** victims.

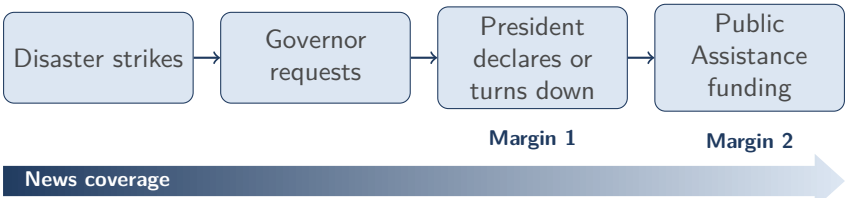
(i) Does coverage affect domestic FEMA disbursement at all?

- The foreign-disaster result need not transplant: political and bureaucratic pressures may drive aid independently of media attention

(ii) Does coverage interact with electoral incentives?

- Coverage could *discipline* it (departures from need are more salient) or *amplify* it (higher electoral return to visible generosity)

Two Margins Where Media and Politics Can Enter



- **Declaration:** the president approves or turns down the state's request
- **Funding:** the federal cost share is at least 75%; it can be raised to 90% or 100%

Roadmap

Roadmap

1. Overview of data sources
2. Aid, need, and politics
   - 2.1 FEMA (aid and declaration data)
   - 2.2 Disaster (type, location, damage)
   - 2.3 State level presidential electoral returns
3. News coverage
4. News pressure
5. Preliminary results
6. Conclusion

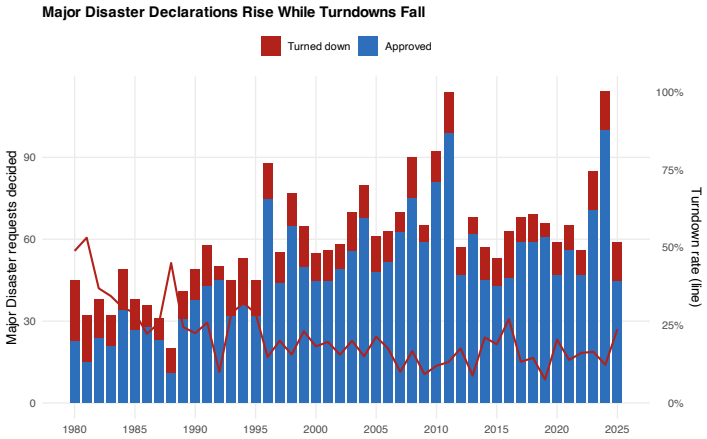
1. Data

Data: Linking Aid, Need, Politics, and News

Source	Content
OpenFEMA	disaster designations (declaration and rejection)
FEMA PA funded projects	≈810k projects: project cost and federal obligation
NOAA Storm Events	disaster-level property and crop damage, deaths, injuries
MIT Election Lab	State presidential election returns
Alignment	Hand-coded governor and president political party and terms
ProQuest TDM Studio	5 national dailies, disaster news coverage
VTNA	ABC/CBS/NBC evening-news segments

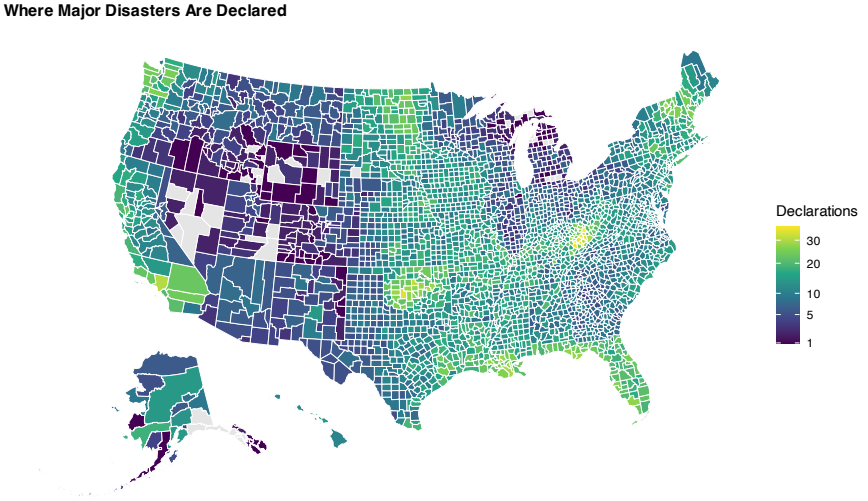
2. Aid, Need, and Politics

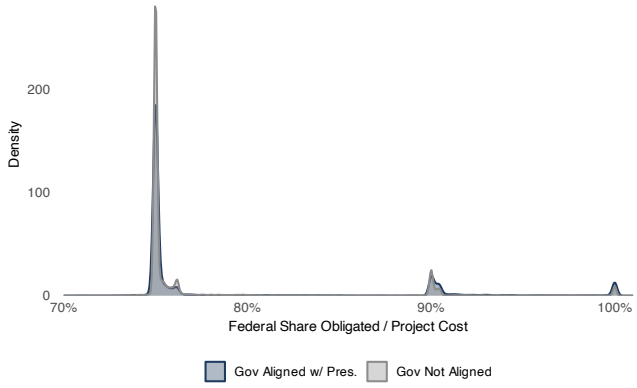
Declarations: One Request in Five Is Turned Down



- 2,225 approvals and 535 turndowns: about one request in five is turned down.

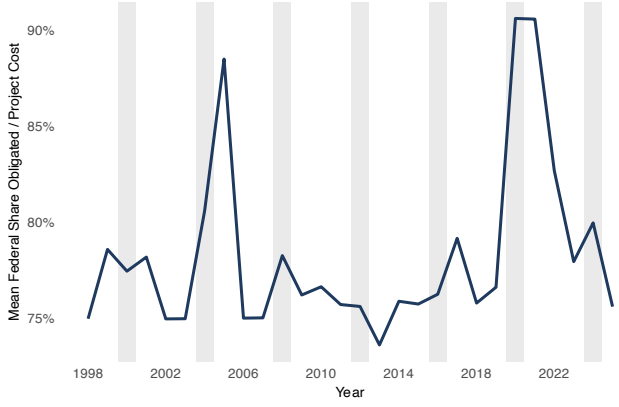
Geography and Intensity of Declaration History





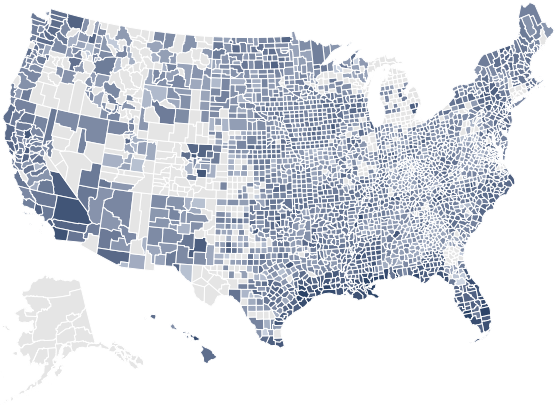
- 65% of projects sit exactly at the 75% floor, 19% at 90%, 15% at 100%.

Cost Shares Spike in Specific Years

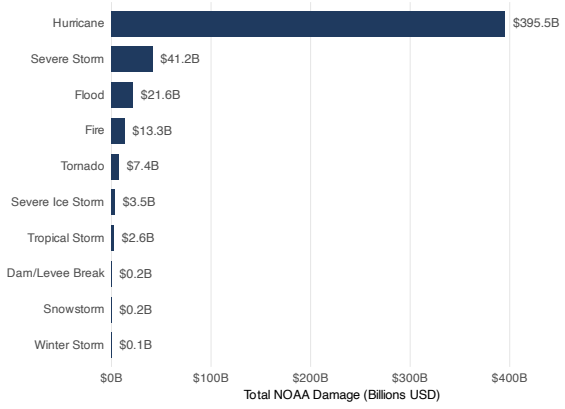


▶ Jumps in 2004–05 (Katrina, Rita) and 2020–21 (COVID-19). Importantly, appears to rise in presidential election years (shaded).

Measuring Need: NOAA Storm Damage

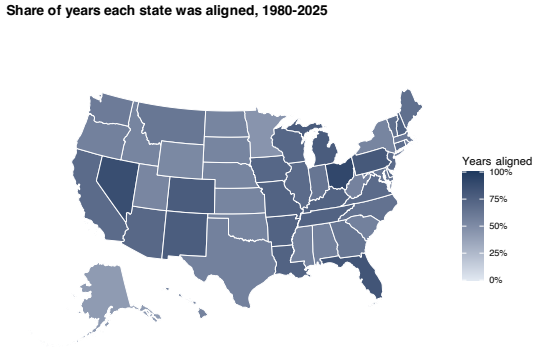


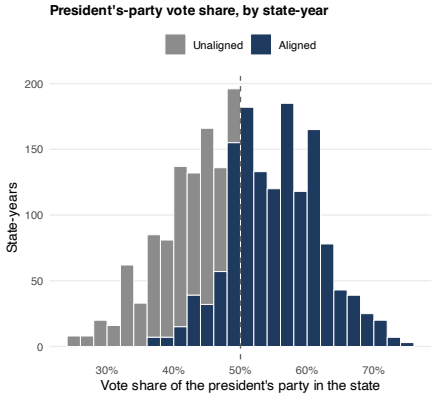
Need Is Dominated by Hurricanes



- Hurricanes account for $396bn of matched damage, nearly 10× severe storms.

Political Alignment





▶ Aligned = the state's plurality winner in the last presidential election is the president's party. 66% of state-years are aligned, and most states switch over time.

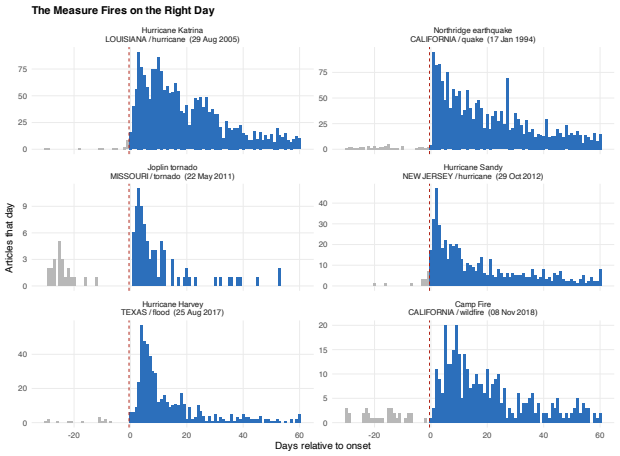
3. News Coverage

Measuring Coverage in Five National Dailies

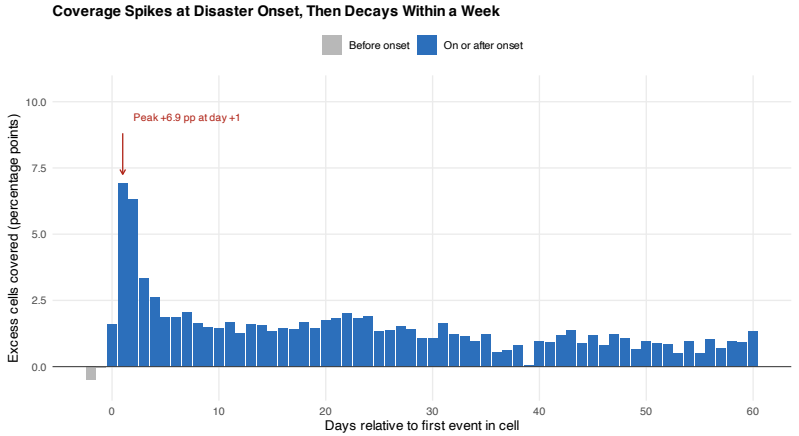
- **Corpus:** 5 dailies via ProQuest TDM Studio, June 1980 – August 2026; 1.38m article mentions (NYT, Washington Post, L.A. Times, WSJ, Chicago Tribune)
- **Unit:** a *cell* = one state $\times$ one 40-day block with NOAA events (15,120 inside the corpus)
- **Match:** article names the state *and* a hazard word from a class present in the cell
- **Window:** $[+2, +40]$ days after onset, following Eisensee & Strömberg (2007)

Three quantities of interest	
Any coverage	≥ 1 matching article in window
Coverage intensity	number of matching articles
Excess coverage	coverage intensity minus the same count in the mirror window prior to event

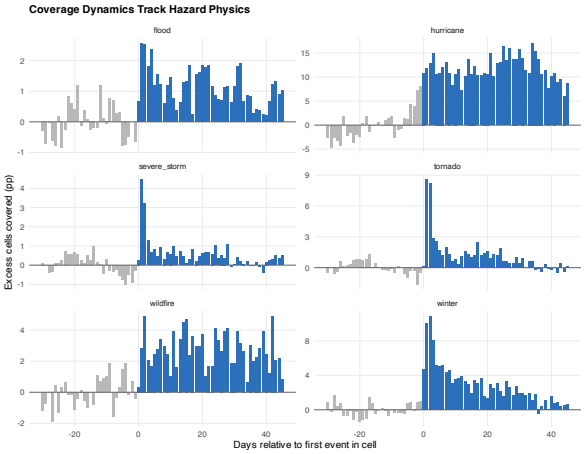
Is Coverage Measured Correctly?



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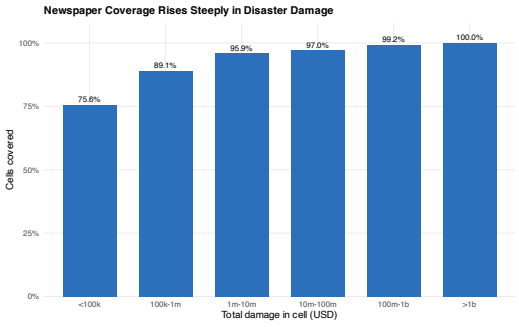


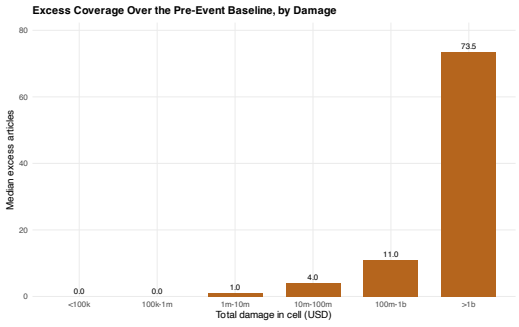
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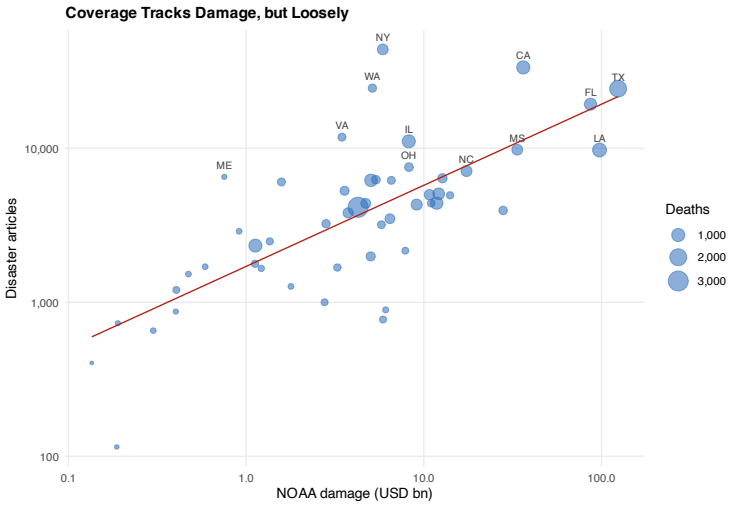
▶ Acute hazards spike and decay, wildfire sustains, and hurricane coverage starts ≈5 days before landfall.

Coverage Is Highly Correlated With Financial Damage . . .



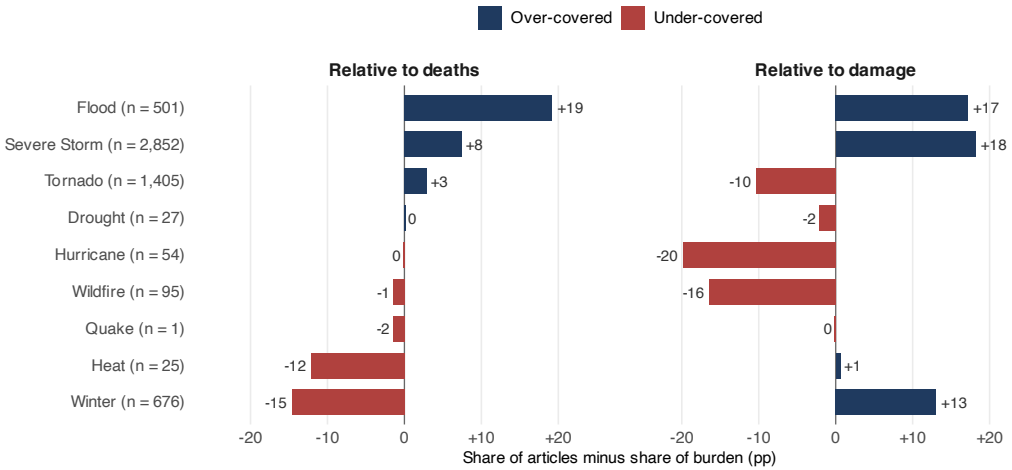


. . . And Deaths

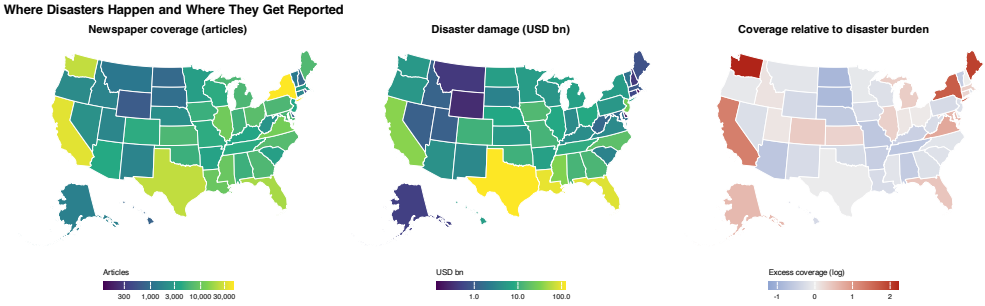


- Coverage is 6.7× more elastic to deaths (0.258) than to dollars of damage (0.039).

Some Hazard Types Are Over- or Under-Covered



Some States Are Over-Represented In News



▶ Each paper over-weights its home state 3–9×: the LA Times sends 22.1% of its disaster coverage to California.

3. News Pressure

Idea: Other Big News Crowds Out Disasters

Eisensee & Strömberg (2007): when other big news dominates, a disaster gets squeezed out of the news, for reasons unrelated to need.

Newspaper index (ProQuest front pages) — in progress

- Built from front-page article lengths in the 5 dailies, 1980–2026
- Still being refined: front-page detection and the right measure of a busy news day

TV index (Vanderbilt Television News Archive) — used for now

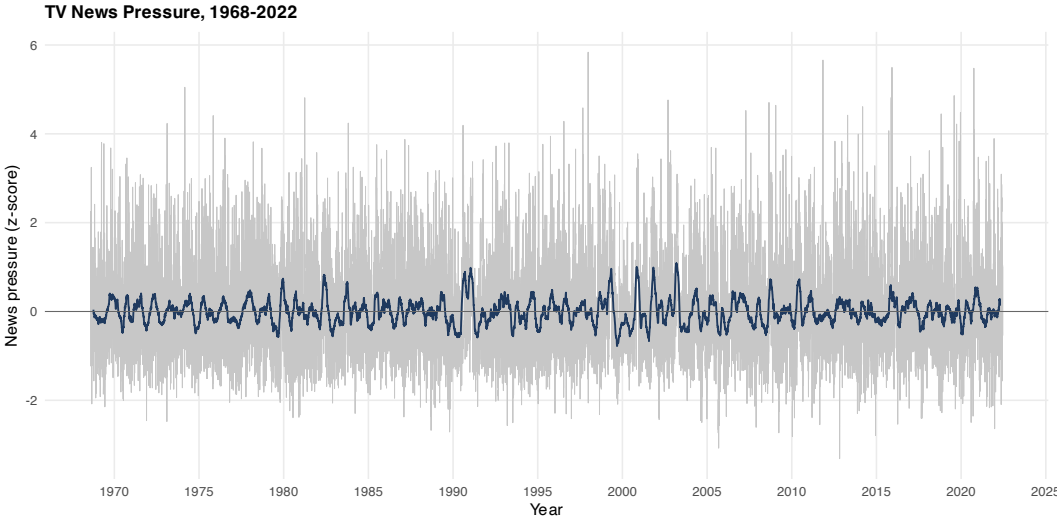
- The E&S original: ABC, CBS, NBC evening news, 1968–June 2022
- A newscast has a fixed length, so long top stories mechanically crowd others out

Building the TV News-Pressure Index

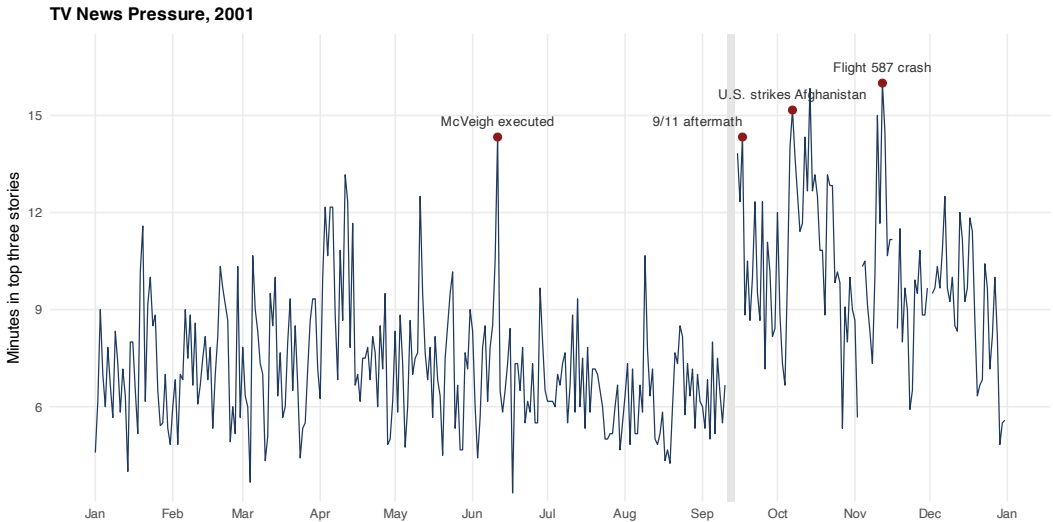
Construction from 962,918 Vanderbilt segments (ABC, CBS, NBC, 1968–June 2022):

- Per broadcast: minutes in the **top three news stories**; per day: median across networks
- **Disaster stories skipped** before picking the top three (3% of segments, by headline), so a disaster cannot raise its own pressure
- Z-scored within day-of-week $\times$ year (z^{TV}, next slides)

Use, as in E&S: average minutes over the **40 days after onset**; disaster-type, state, year and month FE; robust SEs.


TV News Pressure, 1968-2022
6
4
2
0
-2
News pressure (z-score)
1970
1975
1980
1985
1990
1995
2000
2005
2010
2015
2020
2025
Year

Validation: One Year Up Close: 2001



Validation: Big-News Days Rank at the Top

Day	Pctile
Capitol riot (2021)	99.6
Gulf War, day after (1991)	99.1
Oklahoma City bombing (1995)	99.0
Osama bin Laden killed (2011)	99.0
Challenger disaster (1986)	97.8
Berlin Wall, day after (1989)	93.9
Lehman Brothers collapse (2008)	70.8
COVID-19 declared a pandemic (2020)	23.4
Hurricane Katrina (2005)	0.6

- Major non-disaster news days sit at the 94th–99.6th percentile
- Katrina is near zero *by design*: disaster stories are excluded, so a disaster cannot crowd itself out
- 9/11 has no standard broadcast (wall-to-wall coverage)

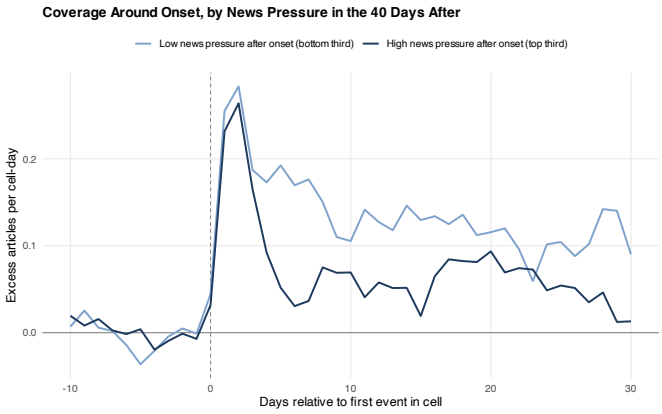
4. Preliminary Results

Instrument: TV news pressure (VTNA), averaged over the 40 days after onset. The newspaper news-pressure index is still in progress, so for now all results use the VTNA index.

Specification (Eisensee & Strömberg 2007), state × 40-day cell c:

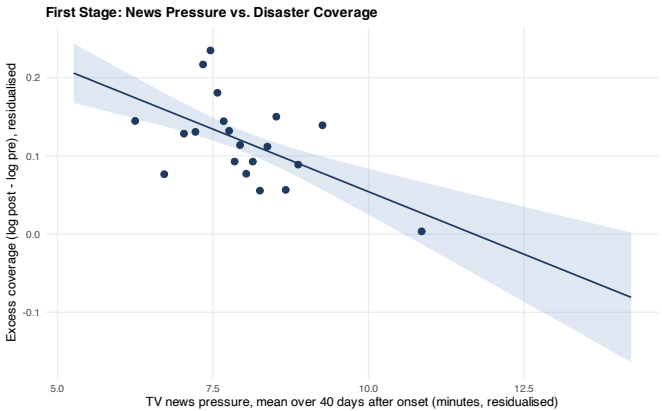
$$\text{Coverage}_c = \pi\,\text{Pressure}_c + \text{FE} + u_c, \qquad \text{Declared}_c = \beta\,\widehat{\text{Coverage}}_c + \text{FE} + e_c$$

- Coverage: excess articles, $\log(1 + \text{post}) - \log(1 + \text{pre})$
- FE: disaster type, state, year, month; heteroskedasticity-robust SEs
- Interaction: add Coverage × Aligned, instrumented by Pressure × Aligned



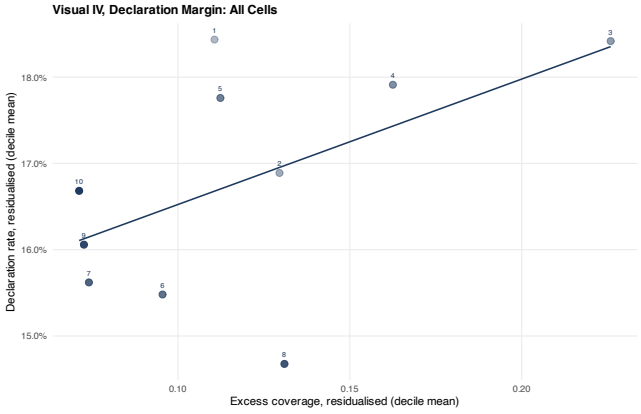
▶ Same pre-onset path and a similar day-2 peak; from day 4 on, high-pressure disasters get less than half the excess coverage (0.06 vs. 0.13 per day).

First Stage: News Pressure Lowers Coverage



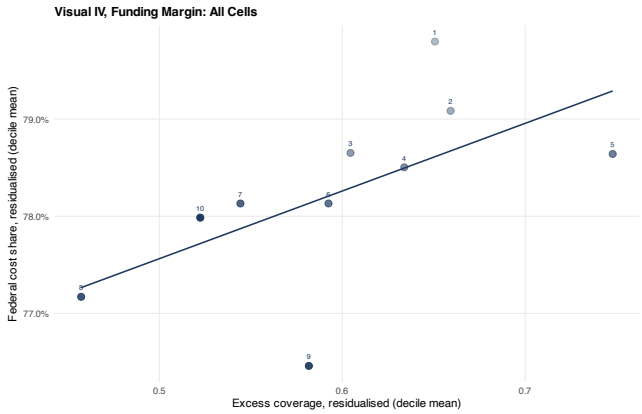
▶ One more minute of non-disaster news per day cuts excess coverage by 3.2% (SE 0.7%); F = 21.9 (17.8 clustered by state).

Main Result: News-Driven Coverage Raises Declarations



▶ More news coverage, more declarations: 2SLS 0.22 (SE 0.10), about +2pp per 0.1 log points of coverage

Funding Margin: Same Sign, Not Yet Reliable



▶ Only 1,140 cells, one per declared disaster: 2SLS 0.13 (SE 0.07) on the cost share, but F = 3.7, so this is not yet reliable.

Work in progress

5. Conclusion

Summary: What I Have Built and Found

Built

- A state $\times$ 40-day panel, 1980–2025, linking FEMA declarations and funding, NOAA damage, and presidential alignment
- A newspaper **coverage** measure from 1.38m articles in 5 dailies, validated on known disasters
- The E&S **TV news-pressure** instrument from 962,918 Vanderbilt segments

Found

- News pressure crowds out coverage ($F = 21.9$)
- News-driven coverage raises declarations (AR 95% set $[0.05,\ 0.46]$)